

TWENTY-FOURTH NORTHERN MARIANAS COMMONWEALTH
LEGISLATURE
IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Session, 2026

H. J. R. 24-21

A HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION

To approve the Governor's request to exempt and fill a critical and vacant personnel position within the Executive Branch, specifically for the CNMI Office of Veterans Affairs, pursuant to Public Law 24-20, Section 602(a).

1 **WHEREAS**, the Twenty-Fourth Northern Marianas Commonwealth
2 Legislature enacted Public Law 24-20, also known as the Revised Appropriations
3 and Budget Authority Act of 2026; and

4 **WHEREAS**, Section 602(a) of Public Law 24-20 mandates a freeze on
5 filling new or vacant positions within the Executive Branch, except for positions
6 essential to the delivery of public services; and

7 **WHEREAS**, Section 602(a) provides a mechanism to exempt critical
8 vacancies from this freeze upon the formal determination and certification of the
9 Governor, subject to approval by the Legislature via a joint resolution; and

10 **WHEREAS**, the CNMI Veterans Cemetery serves as the final resting place
11 for our military veterans and their eligible family members; It is a place of honor,
12 dignity, and remembrance that must be maintained in accordance with established

1 cemetery standards to ensure a respectful environment for veterans, their families,
2 and the public; and

3 **WHEREAS**, a vacancy in the grounds maintenance position compromises
4 the physical infrastructure, facility systems, and operational safety of the Veterans
5 Cemetery that requires dedicated upkeep to prevent costly structural degradation
6 and is necessary to preserve the appearance, safety, and functionality of the
7 cemetery; and

8 **WHEREAS**, through Governor's Communication 24-185, the Governor
9 has formally certified to the Legislature that the vacant grounds maintenance
10 position within the CNMI Office of Veterans Affairs is essential for the delivery of
11 public services; and

12 **WHEREAS**, the Legislature finds that honoring our veterans by properly
13 maintaining their dedicated public facilities is a necessary public service that
14 justifies an exemption from the hiring freeze;

15 **NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED**, by the House of
16 Representatives of the Twenty-Fourth Northern Marianas Commonwealth
17 Legislature, the Senate concurring, that the following personnel is essential for the
18 delivery of public service and approved by the Legislature:

19 1 Ground Maintenance, CNMI Office of Veterans Affairs

20 **BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED**, that the Speaker of the House of
21 Representatives and the President of the Senate shall certify, and the House Clerk

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 24-21

1 and the Senate Legislative Secretary shall attest to the adoption of this joint
2 resolution, and thereafter the House Clerk shall transmit a copy to Jose DLG.
3 Crisostomo, Executive Officer, CNMI Office of Veterans Affairs; Natalia M.
4 Sablan, Acting Secretary, Department of Finance; Virginia C. Villagomez, Special
5 Assistant, Office of Management and Budget; Joseph M. Pangelinan, Director,
6 Office of Personnel and Management; and the Honorable David M. Apatang,
7 Governor, Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands.

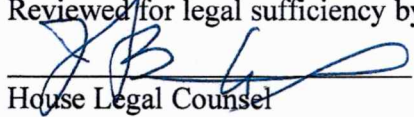
Prefiled: 9/27/2024

Date: _____

Introduced by: _____


Rep. John Paul P. Sablan

Reviewed for legal sufficiency by:


House Legal Counsel

Date: _____